

# POOR FIELD EXPERIMENTS CAN BE WORSE THAN USELESS

FIELD EXPERIMENTS

## IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

**Joseph Connell** (1923–2020)

BEFORE

**1856** British scientists John Lawes and Joseph Gilbert start to test how different fertilizers affect yields in hay meadows, in the Park Grass Experiment.

**1938** French ecologist Harry Hatton’s field experiments on barnacles in Brittany are one of the first in marine biology.

AFTER

**1966** US ecologist Robert Paine tests how the absence of the starfish *Pisaster ochraceus* from tide pools in an ecosystem affects other species.

**1968** The Experimental Lakes Area is established in Ontario, Canada, to study the effects of nutrient enrichment (eutrophication).

**2011** The Stability of Altered Forest Ecosystems (SAFE) project is launched.

Experimentation is crucial in ecology. Without it, our ideas about why organisms behave the way they do would be largely speculative. Rigorous